parties and the political system of Pakistan. The lack of understanding of political awareness was clearly indicative of the failure of the education system in inculcating civic values and responsibilities (see Chapter 4). However, the participants also did not link political awareness to university-level politics. The main focus of their discussion on awareness linked to politics was the mainstream political parties and the rhetoric employed by these politicians. The first narrative takes this political awareness 'across the border', highlighting the significance of geopolitics in defining the political reality of Pakistan. Chapter 4 discusses the problematic narratives associated with countries 'across the border' that are held responsible, often solely responsible for internal threats and issues around terrorism: '*To be aware of the current political context/scenario of the state and also across the border*' (Student, Female, Lahore); '*Khoobsurat alfaaz ka mujmuah jiss par amal nahi hota*'[26] (Academic, Female, Lahore). While 'across the border' reality is an important aspect of political awareness, religion is also part of this understanding. Political awareness has to be within the context of Islam, since '*this is a religious state*'. The existence of the arch-enemy across the border (read: India), and the significance of Islam in defining our sense of political awareness, reveals the extent to which the discourse on Pakistan linked to Islam has been normalized: '*As we know this is a religious state, so every work according to Islam. If we know this state then work according to it*' (Student, Female, Kasur).

However, among the shared definitions were also meanings that stood out, where the '*know how about politics*' (Student, Female, Lahore) was connected to the hope that by better understanding the political structure one will be able to improve it. This kind of optimism, though, was more an exception to the narratives than the norm: '*Siyaasi shaaur sei hum mulk ko behtar tareequei sei chala saktei hain*'[27] (Student, Female, Lahore).

Political activism was further understood as moving beyond awareness and taking part in formal politics at the national and provincial levels. '*Activism is the next step after awareness. The knowledge you actually have in which you believe*' (Focus Group, Private University[28]). However, again as was the case with the term 'political' the responses often included value judgements about the nature of politics in Pakistan, and activism linked to it. One participant dismissed it as a *'publicity stunt'* (Student, Female, Lahore), while another described it simply as *'chaos'* (Student, Female, Lahore). Academics from a government sector university also had similar negative connotations attached to political activism, but what was revealing for these academics in particular was that they belonged to the Islamiyat department of a university in Lahore which Nelson (2011)